

refund forms. We signed in, paid a small fee that covered lunch, sat at one of the tables, and started trading. We had a ball. There was never any money involved. We had a great time and met many men and women who enjoyed our hobby. The women who ran the convention had all kinds of door prizes, and the money we paid to attend was used toward the rental of the fire hall where the convention was held. We were able to attend two conventions and came home with lots of forms and coupons to use.”

In 1982, postal authorities had begun an investigation code-named “Rebategate” that eventually netted indictments in 1987. The defendants were accused of using false names and addresses and counterfeit cash register tapes to bilk manufacturers out of more than eighty thousand dollars in refunds and rebates. This wasn’t the first of such investigations, nor would it be the last. But the fallout wasn’t immediately felt by the refund community, at least not until authorities began scrutinizing housewives and church groups.

In 1987, a Michigan couple was indicted on charges of illegally receiving twenty-four thousand dollars from a “\$100 rebate” program offered by RJR Nabisco Inc. and RCA Corporation. Some might argue that the company should have foreseen the potential for fraud when they offered such a large sum and only required a sales receipt as proof of purchase for the RCA products. They didn’t have the foresight to limit the refund to one per family or address either. Evidently they hadn’t even considered the possibility of counterfeit cash register tapes.